from splitting with the other, and bound together by their belief that India is a mortal enemy. Nor is Lashkar's prioritization of India as the main enemy solely a function of its relationship with the army or ISI. The group did not launch a jihad against India in order to solicit state support, though receiving it influenced its decision to prioritize that fight. Two decades spent waging war against India has hallowed that cause, to paraphrase another German philosopher, for many of the group's members.[9] This remains the case even as Lashkar's leaders admit that some of their cadres now are driven more by the fight against America.

If one reframes the question 'Is Lashkar the next al-Qaeda,' however, to read 'Does Lashkar threaten the US and its Western allies at home and abroad' then the answer is yes. First, its role in Afghanistan is expanding, though it remains a secondary player. Lashkar boasts a stable of explosives experts and its fighters are adept at small unit tactics, meaning it can make a qualitative contribution to the cause even without substantially increasing its quantitative input. Second, the inclusion of foreign targets for attacks in India is part of a trend that could continue. Third, Lashkar appears prepared to consider acting as the lead agent in terrorist attacks against Western countries, having done so in Australia during the early years of the decade and in Denmark more recently. Yet, Lashkar need not take the lead role in order for its training apparatus and transnational networks to be used against the US or its Western allies. Indeed, the current threat to Western interests comes from a conglomeration of actors working in concert. Notably, working as part of a consortium provides cover for the group, since shared responsibility makes it easier for Lashkar to conceal its fingerprints. One could imagine a scenario in which would-be Western jihadis looking to fight in Afghanistan linked up with a facilitator connected with Lashkar to access a training camp in territory controlled by the Haqqani Network where al-Qaeda convinced them to launch a terrorist attack in a Western country and Lashkar trainers provided some of the instruction. In addition to the contributions it can make in Pakistan, nodes in the group's transnational networks are able to provide reconnaissance, financial support or other logistical assistance for such an attack. Elements from such a scenario have occurred already, as this book has illustrated with regard to Lashkar trainees and members operating in the US, UK and Europe, Persian Gulf and Australia.